

Session 6: From Deficit to Asset-Based Mentoring

This week's lesson focuses on shifting from a deficit-based to an asset-based mindset in mentoring, particularly when supporting students of color. Through the discussion of two key papers, we'll explore how mentors can reframe their perspectives to better recognize and nurture the strengths students bring to academic spaces. One activity involves reading a paper that compares mentoring to plant care, encouraging participants to extend the analogy by using their own knowledge of plant biology as a metaphor for how they might approach student well-being. We'll also engage in a conversation about the specific assets students of color bring to our workplaces and practice naming and affirming those assets. These activities will lay the foundation for establishing more equitable and supportive mentoring relationships.

Things for facilitators to be prepared for:

Facilitators should be prepared to guide the discussion into practical ways mentors can create environments where mentees' existing strengths are recognized and supported. Facilitators should be prepared to create multiple break-out rooms.

Participant Pre-Work:

- **Objective:** Students will read two selected papers to build a foundational understanding of how mentoring approaches can shift from deficit-based to asset-based mindsets. This preparation will enable them to actively engage in discussions about recognizing and valuing the strengths students of color bring to academic spaces.
 - **Activities:**
 - **Article 1:** [From Deficits to Possibilities](#), Beronda L. Montgomery
 - **Article 2:** [Whose Culture has Capital?](#) Tara J. Yosso
 - Starting at P. 77, 1. Aspirational Capital and ending on P.81 before the Discussion section
 - **Reflection:** How does the analogy of the relationship between humans and plants shift or deepen your understanding of what it means to support students? What strengths or assets can be observed in students of color that may be overlooked when viewed through a deficit lens?
 - **Submission:** Be ready to share your reflections during the live session.
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Synchronous Session:

- **Materials Needed:**
 - [Session 6 Slides](#)
 - [Session 7 pre-work sign-up sheet](#)
 - [Session 6 Survey](#)
 - [Survey results from previous sessions](#)

- Access to Zoom and familiarity creating break-out rooms
- **Learning Objectives:**
 - **Objective 1:** Identify the differences between deficit-based and asset-based mindsets in mentoring relationships
 - **Objective 2:** Apply the plant care analogy to recognize signs of student distress and consider responsive, supportive mentoring practices
 - **Objective 3:** Practice naming and affirming the assets of students of color to foster strengths-based mentoring approaches
- **Reviewing Survey Results:**
 - Before each session, all facilitators should plan to [review the survey results from the previous session](#). This is so they are able to incorporate any participant feedback into their session and make any adjustments.
- **Pework for Facilitator 2:**
 - Set all observers/facilitators as hosts (unless they want to be assigned to breakout rooms)
 - Set up screen with 5-minute Google timer, ready to share
 - Set up first breakout room: Random assignment of 3 people/room with 8-minute auto-recall
 - **Facilitator 2** starts recording, **Facilitator 3** backs up at starting/stopping recording for breakouts
 - **Facilitator 3** starts recording.
- Note for all facilitators: make sure to rename yourself as “Facilitator” in the Zoom name.

Live Session Agenda:

- **Welcome and Warm-up Activity: 00:00 - 00:05 (5 min)**
 - Start with a one-word check-in using a chat waterfall to help everyone arrive and be present. **Facilitator 1** will say to the group:
 - *“Take a moment to reflect on how you’re arriving today. In one word, how are you feeling right now? Type your word in the chat, but don’t hit enter yet. I’ll count down, and we’ll all hit enter at the same time.”*
 - **Facilitator 2** posts prompt in chat: How are you feeling right now?
 - After everyone shares, **Facilitator 1** will acknowledge the range of responses and name any common themes you notice (e.g., *“I see a mix of ‘tired,’ ‘curious,’ and ‘focused’—thanks for sharing that.”*)
- **Reflection Review: 00:05 - 00:15 (10 min)**
 - **Activity Type:** Small breakout room activity
 - **Description:** Participants will break into small groups to reflect on the plant care analogy from the reading. **Facilitator 1** introduces the activity. **Facilitator 2** will post these three questions to the chat while **Facilitator 1** reads them aloud:
 - How does thinking about mentoring as plant care shift your understanding of what students need to thrive?

- Can you think of a time when a student was showing signs of “nutrient deficiency” or distress? How did you respond, and how might you respond differently now?
 - What parallels do you see between the care your research subjects (plants) need and the care mentees or students might need?
 - **Facilitator 2** randomly assign non-hosts to breakout rooms (3 per room, preset with 8 min time auto-recall)
 - **Facilitator 3** stops recording during the breakouts
 - **Facilitator 2** broadcasts a 3-minute warning before breakouts end
- **Large Group Discussion: 00:15 - 00:25 (10 min)**
 - **Description:** **Facilitator 1** invites groups back to the main rooms and asks one representative from each group to share one highlight from their discussion
 - **Facilitator 2** will prompt to move on approximately every three minutes, so ~00:18, 00:21.
- **BREAK: 00:25 - 00:30 (5 min)**
 - **Facilitator 2** shares their screen with the timer countdown and takes [attendance](#)
 - **Facilitator 3:** Stop recording during break, restarts recording after break
- **Reflection Review: Community Cultural Wealth & Student Assets: 00:30 - 00:55 (25 min)**
 - **Activity Type:** Large Group Discussion
 - **Description:** **Facilitator 1** guides participants to reflect on the Community Cultural Wealth (CCW) framework and how it applies to students of color in their own workplace or mentoring contexts. In a large group setting, participants will be prompted to share examples of specific assets they’ve observed in students of color and reflect on how recognizing those assets might shift their mentoring approach.
 - **Facilitator 2** will share [slide 10 from this slideshow](#) with the CCW framework for participant reference.
 - **Facilitator 2** will post these questions in the chat one at a time (allow equal time for each prompt, so move on around 00:38, 00:46) while Facilitator 1 reads them aloud and guides the discussion.
 - Which types of cultural wealth (aspirational, navigational, social, linguistic, familial, resistant) stood out to you in the reading?
 - If we think about people of color and the type of obstacles they face, we all think about them in a deficit way. Using this CCW lens, what are some of the ways in which we can imagine that people of color or other marginalized people can contribute to these environments and to their research? In other words, what strengths and contributions do students of color bring to your field, lab, or mentoring environment, and how can those be more intentionally recognized?

- How might your mentoring change if you consistently approached mentees with this asset-based lens?
- **BREAK: 00:55 - 01:00 (5 min)**
 - **Facilitator 2** shares their screen with the timer countdown
 - **Facilitator 3:** Stop recording during break, start recording after break
- **Connecting Plant Care to Mentees: 01:00 - 01:15 (15 min)**
 - **Activity Type:** Breakout Groups
 - **Description:** **Facilitator 1** will introduce the activity.
 - *"We have these two frameworks, one on plant lessons and one on Community Cultural Wealth (CCW), and we are going to combine them. For example, Plant Lesson 2 is that sometimes existing resources just need to be relocated. In the CCW framework, we have linguistic capital. The mentoring practice combination would be that the mentor connects students with peers who are bilingual or from a similar background who can support them."*
 - **Facilitator 2** shares their screen with [slide 2](#) as an example, and will then share the [full slideshow](#) in the chat for participant reference.
 - **Facilitator 1** explains the breakout rooms:
 - *"We are going to open two breakout rooms per plant lesson/CCW pair, and you will be randomly assigned to one of them. You will work in your breakout room to brainstorm one concrete practice a mentor can enact that combines both approaches"*
 - **Facilitator 2:** Participants will be randomly distributed in a breakout room that assigns one plant lesson / CCW pairing. Then, participants will brainstorm one concrete practice a mentor can enact that combines both approaches.
 - **Facilitator 2** pastes in the chat while **Facilitator 1** reads aloud:
 - Option 1:
 - Plant lesson 1: We extensively probe our environment when the plants in it are not faring well.
 - CCW: Aspirational capital
 - Option 2:
 - Plant lesson 3: Caretakers and their preparation, expertise, and efficacy critically matter to plant persistence and optimized survival.
 - CCW: Resistant capital
 - Option 3:
 - Plant lesson 4: We seek external expertise when our own caretaking efforts prove ineffective.
 - CCW: Social capital
 - Option 4:
 - Plant lesson 5: We attribute a failure to support plant growth to our own caretaking and stewardship inabilities
 - CCW: Navigational capital

- **Facilitator 2:** Open breakout rooms named with each option, so that when participants join they know which option they will be working on. Randomly assign groups of 3, auto-return after 13 minutes.
 - **Facilitator 3 stops recording during the breakouts**
 - **Facilitator 2** broadcasts a 3-minute warning before breakouts end
 - **Large Group Discussion: 01:15 - 01:27 (12 min)**
 - **Description:** **Facilitator 1** selects one participant from each option and asks them to share.
 - *“Please raise your Zoom hand if you chose Option 1 and share the mentoring practice that you brainstormed”*
 - Participants share their results with the group while **Facilitator 2** takes notes on practical strategies in the slides ([slide 11](#)). **Facilitator 2** should not share their notes until the end.
 - **Facilitator 2** or **Facilitator 3:** Retype instructions into the chat for each of the options until all have been discussed. Note: so that every option gets equal time, three minutes should be allocated to each, so switch at ~01:18, 01:21, 01:24).
 - **Wrap-Up: 01:27 - 01:30 (3 min)**
 - **Facilitator 1** wraps up the session by summarizing the key takeaways: the importance of shifting from a deficit to an asset-based mindset; the power of analogies like plant care in reframing mentoring; and the value of recognizing the Community Cultural Wealth that students of color bring to academic spaces. Invite participants to share any final questions, comments, or insights from today’s discussion.
 - **Facilitator 2** shares the link to the [Session 6 Survey](#) in the chat and asks participants to complete it as soon as they can.
 - **Facilitator 1** asks participants to sign up for a scenario as part of their pre-work for Session 7, while **Facilitator 2** posts the [link to the sign-up sheet](#) in the chat. Remind participants that the sign-up sheet has the link to the actual scenarios for them to take a look at before they make a decision.
 - **Facilitator 1** thanks everyone for joining and ends the session.
 - **Facilitator 3 stops the recording.**
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Facilitator Notes:

The Facilitators should spend time writing down everything they observed during the session (what worked, what didn’t, and what improvements need to be made). They can also include advice for the next facilitator to watch out for. Facilitators may use the following guiding questions:

- How did the session go?
- Was there active participation in discussions?
- Do you feel like the learning objectives were met?
- Are there topics that need to be revisited in the next session?

- Were participants fully engaged when discussing their own mentoring experiences or goals?
- Were there times of vulnerability, disagreement, or hesitation? How were they managed?
- Did the conversation about group norms seem genuine and open? Were any important issues addressed?
- Are there any organizational improvements (tech, timing, breakout structure) to be addressed before the next session?